GRE Program Score Target Worksheet

MS vs MBA Score Benchmarks, Section-Level Quant/Verbal Prioritization & Program-Specific Matrices

1. Program-Specific GRE Target Score Matrix (MS vs MBA vs Specialized Masters)

Benchmark your target scores across top engineering, computer science, data analytics, and business programs.

Academic Program & Discipline	Typical Quant Target (130-170)	Typical Verbal Target (130-170)	Competitive Total Score	Key Evaluation Emphasis
MS in Computer Science / AI (Top 10 US)	167 – 170 (90th–97th %ile)	154 – 158 (60th–78th %ile)	324 – 328+	Near-perfect Quant mandatory; Verbal is secondary
MS in Data Science / Business Analytics	166 – 169 (88th–95th %ile)	156 – 160 (70th–85th %ile)	324 – 328+	High Quant + solid Verbal analytical writing
Top 10 MBA Programs (Harvard, Stanford)	164 – 167 (82nd–90th %ile)	162 – 166 (90th–97th %ile)	328 – 333+	Both sections evaluated equally; high balance required
Top 25 MBA Programs (ISB, Ross, Fuqua)	161 – 165 (74th–85th %ile)	158 – 162 (78th–90th %ile)	320 – 326+	Solid scores that meet or exceed class medians
MS in Mechanical / Electrical Engineering	164 – 168 (82nd–93rd %ile)	152 – 156 (53rd–70th %ile)	318 – 324+	High math focus; research pedigree and SOP matter most
Masters in Public Policy / International Affairs	154 – 158 (53rd–67th %ile)	163 – 167 (92nd–98th %ile)	320 – 325+	High Verbal & Analytical Writing (AWA 4.5+) prioritized

Scoring Scale: GRE Quant and Verbal are scored from 130 to 170 in 1-point increments; AWA is scored from 0 to 6.0 in half-point increments.

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2. Minimum Scores vs Typical Admitted Averages

Why clearing a university's stated minimum threshold does NOT guarantee admission.

Evaluation Parameter	University Stated Minimum Score	Actual Admitted Student Median	Admissions Takeaway
Top Tier MS in CS (e.g. CMU, Georgia Tech)	Often listed as 155Q or "None"	168Q, 158V, 4.0 AWA	Minimums merely prevent automatic filtering; admitted averages are far higher
Ivy League Engineering (e.g. Columbia)	158Q, 150V	167Q, 156V, 4.0 AWA	Quant score below 165 requires exceptional research publications to survive review
Top Global MBA (e.g. Wharton, ISB)	No official minimum published	Wharton: 162Q, 162V / ISB: 164Q, 158V	Adcoms seek parity with high GMAT percentiles; aim for combined 324+

Worksheet Rule: Set your target score 3 to 5 points above the published median of your target program.

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3. Actionable Program-Specific Goal Setting Protocol

Follow this 4-step worksheet to lock in your official GRE score goal.

- Step 1: Segment Target Programs into Tier 1 (Reach), Tier 2 (Target), and Tier 3 (Safety).
- Step 2: Determine Primary Discipline Priority: STEM programs weight Quant 80/20; MBA programs weight 50/50; Humanities weight Verbal 80/20.
- Step 3: Establish Sectional Floors. Never allow your secondary section to fall below the 50th percentile (152V for engineers, 155Q for humanities).
- Step 4: Audit Analytical Writing (AWA). Ensure you practice enough timed essays to secure at least a 4.0 for STEM/MBA or 4.5+ for policy/humanities.